

■ STUDY BEES ■

PLAY

The Oyster and the Pearl

by
Rex Warner

- About the Play
- Characters — Protagonist & Antagonist
- Summary
- Plot Structure (Rising Action to Resolution)
- Themes
- Literary Devices
- SLO-Based Questions & Answers

About the Play

The Oyster and the Pearl is a stage adaptation, written by Rex Warner, of John Steinbeck's novella *The Pearl*. It keeps Steinbeck's parable-like story of a poor pearl-diving family but reshapes it into dialogue and stage action suitable for performance. The play is set among a community of poor Mexican pearl divers who live under the shadow of a nearby town controlled by wealthy, mostly foreign, traders and professionals.

Like the original novella, the play works as a moral fable: it uses one family's misfortune to comment on the corrupting power of sudden wealth, the gap between the rich and the poor, and the way greed can destroy love, hope and innocence.

Characters

Protagonist

Kino — A poor, hard-working pearl diver and the head of his small family. He is honest, proud and deeply devoted to his wife and son. His discovery of a magnificent pearl turns him from a contented, humble man into someone consumed by ambition, suspicion and, eventually, violence, as he tries to protect the one chance he believes will free his family from poverty.

Deuteragonist

Juana — Kino's wife. She is patient, practical and instinctively wise. She senses early that the pearl is dangerous and repeatedly urges Kino to throw it away, making her the voice of caution and moral clarity against her husband's growing obsession.

Coyotito — The infant son of Kino and Juana. His scorpion sting sets the whole story in motion, and his fate at the end of the story delivers the play's harshest lesson about the cost of greed.

Antagonists / Antagonistic Forces

The Doctor — A greedy town physician who refuses to treat Coyotito because Kino is poor, then changes his attitude only once he learns of the pearl. He represents the prejudice and exploitation of the poor by those in power.

The Pearl Buyers — Town dealers who conspire to cheat Kino by offering an unfairly low price for the pearl, representing organised commercial greed.

The Trackers — Armed men who pursue Kino to rob him of the pearl; they are the direct physical threat that leads to the story's tragedy. Beyond the human antagonists, the pearl itself functions as a symbolic antagonist — a stroke of fortune that awakens greed in everyone who learns of it.

Other Characters

- **Juan Tomás** — Kino's older brother, loyal and protective, who shelters and advises the family.
- **The Priest** — Visits Kino after news of the pearl spreads, hinting that the church, too, hopes to benefit.
- **Neighbours and Townsfolk** — Their gossip and envy spread news of the pearl and increase the danger around Kino's family.

Summary

Kino, Juana and their baby son Coyotito live simply in a brush house by the sea, where Kino dives for pearls to sell in the town market. One morning a scorpion stings Coyotito. When the family rushes to the town doctor, he turns them away because they cannot pay. Desperate, Kino goes diving and finds an extraordinarily large and beautiful pearl, which he believes is the answer to all his family's problems: money for medicine, a proper marriage in church, an education for his son.

News of the pearl spreads quickly. The doctor suddenly appears, offering treatment, and secretly worsens Coyotito's condition so he can appear to cure him and demand payment. The pearl buyers, acting together, try to convince Kino the pearl is worthless so they can buy it cheaply; Kino refuses to sell and decides to travel to the capital to get a fair price instead. That night, unknown men attack Kino to steal the pearl; he fights them off but is injured, and his canoe is later destroyed and his house burned by intruders searching for the pearl.

Fearing for their lives, the family flees into the mountains, pursued by armed trackers. Juana again begs Kino to throw the pearl into the sea, but he refuses, now consumed by pride and the belief that the pearl is his destiny. Hiding in a cave, Kino confronts and kills the trackers after they fire toward the family's hiding place, but in the darkness and violence Coyotito is killed by a stray shot. Grief-stricken, Kino and Juana walk back into town together, and Kino throws the pearl back into the sea, rejecting the wealth that has cost him his son.

Plot Structure

Exposition

The story opens with Kino, Juana and Coyotito living a simple, contented life by the sea; Kino's morning routine and his love for his family establish the peaceful world that will soon be disrupted.

Inciting Incident

A scorpion stings Coyotito, and the doctor's refusal to treat a poor family without payment sets the plot in motion, pushing Kino to go pearl diving with a new urgency.

Rising Action

Kino finds the great pearl. His decision to keep it and seek his fortune sets off a chain of escalating threats: the doctor's false treatment, the buyers' attempt to cheat him, a night attack on his home, the burning of his house and destruction of his canoe, and finally the family's flight into the mountains pursued by trackers.

Climax

In the mountain cave, as the trackers close in and fire shots toward the family's hiding place, Kino attacks and kills the trackers — the story's most intense point of violence and danger.

Anticlimax / Tragic Turn

The apparent triumph of defeating the trackers collapses immediately: in the same moment of violence, Coyotito is killed by a stray bullet, turning what could have been a victory into the story's greatest loss.

Falling Action

Devastated, Kino and Juana leave the mountains and walk silently back toward the town, carrying their dead son, the pearl still in Kino's possession.

Denouement and Resolution

Reaching the shore together, Kino offers the pearl to Juana to throw away, but instead throws it himself back into the sea. The family returns to poverty, but Kino rejects the wealth and ambition that destroyed his peace and his son, restoring, in a bitter way, the family's original simplicity.

Themes

- **The Corrupting Power of Wealth:** the pearl, a symbol of fortune, gradually turns a loving, contented man into a suspicious, violent one.
- **Greed vs. Contentment:** almost every character who learns of the pearl is driven by greed, while Juana repeatedly represents the wiser, more contented path.
- **Poverty and Social Injustice:** the doctor's and buyers' treatment of Kino exposes how the poor are exploited and disrespected by those with power and money.
- **Fate and Free Will:** the play raises the question of whether Kino's downfall was destined the moment he found the pearl, or the result of his own choices.
- **Family and Loss:** the bond between Kino, Juana and Coyotito is the emotional core of the play, and its destruction gives the story its tragic weight.
- **Materialism vs. Human Values:** the play contrasts the pursuit of material wealth with the simpler, more valuable bonds of family and community.

Literary Devices

- **Symbolism:** the pearl symbolises both hope/opportunity and the corrupting force of greed; the scorpion symbolises the sudden intrusion of misfortune into a peaceful life.
- **Irony:** the pearl that was meant to bring the family security instead brings violence and the death of the very child it was found to protect.
- **Foreshadowing:** Juana's early unease and warnings about the pearl hint at the tragedy to come.
- **Parable / Allegory:** the story functions as a moral fable about human nature and greed rather than a purely realistic tale.
- **Contrast:** the poverty of Kino's brush house is set against the comfort of the town and the doctor's home, highlighting social inequality.
- **Imagery:** vivid descriptions of the sea, the pearl's glow, and the darkness of the mountains reinforce the play's shifting moods from hope to danger.

SLO-Based Questions & Answers

Q: Who is the author of The Oyster and the Pearl?

Ans: Rex Warner, who adapted the play from John Steinbeck's novella The Pearl.

Q: Why does the doctor initially refuse to treat Coyotito?

Ans: Because Kino and Juana are poor and cannot pay him, showing the doctor's greed and prejudice against the poor.

Q: What does Kino find that changes his family's life?

Ans: Kino finds an unusually large, valuable pearl while diving, which he calls the 'Pearl of the World.'

Q: How do the pearl buyers try to cheat Kino?

Ans: They work together and pretend the pearl is flawed or worthless in order to buy it from him at an unfairly low price.

Q: Who repeatedly advises Kino to get rid of the pearl, and why?

Ans: Juana, because she senses from the beginning that the pearl will bring only trouble and destroy their peace.

Q: What happens to Kino's house and canoe during the play?

Ans: His house is searched and burned, and his canoe — his only means of livelihood — is deliberately destroyed by intruders hunting for the pearl.

Q: Why does the family flee into the mountains?

Ans: To escape armed trackers who are pursuing Kino in order to steal the pearl, after earlier attackers failed to take it from him.

Q: What is the climax of the play?

Ans: Kino's violent confrontation with the trackers in the mountain cave, where he fights to protect his family and the pearl.

Q: What tragic event follows immediately after the climax?

Ans: Coyotito is killed by a stray shot during the confrontation, turning Kino's apparent victory into devastating loss.

Q: How does the play end?

Ans: Kino and Juana return to the shore together, and Kino throws the pearl back into the sea, rejecting the wealth that destroyed their family's happiness.

Q: What does the pearl symbolise in the play?

Ans: It symbolises both the hope of a better life and the corrupting, destructive power of sudden wealth and greed.

Q: What is the central theme of The Oyster and the Pearl?

Ans: That the pursuit of material wealth, when driven by greed, can corrupt human character and destroy what matters most — family, love and peace.

Q: How is social injustice portrayed in the play?

Ans: Through the doctor's and the pearl buyers' treatment of Kino, which shows how the poor are exploited and undervalued by those with wealth and power.

Q: What role does Juan Tomás play in the story?

Ans: He is Kino's brother, who shelters and supports the family and voices concern about the dangers Kino faces from the townspeople.

Q: What lesson does the play ultimately teach?

Ans: That true contentment lies in family and simple human bonds, not in material riches, and that greed — once awakened — can bring tragedy even to the innocent.